

Boxer crab

Lybia tessellata

walking legs covered
in short hairs



The boxer crab's slender pincer-bearing legs are of no use for attack or defense. Instead, it uses a pair of sea anemones as bodyguards. It grips them in its front pincers and thrusts their stinging tentacles at anything threatening. This relationship also

benefits the anemones as they are carried through the water, allowing them to collect food particles suspended in it. The crab cannot catch its own food and so uses its long mouthparts to collect some of the food scraps snared by the anemones.

↔ 3/8–1 in (1–2.5 cm)

⊗ Not known

≡ Plankton



W. Indian Ocean, W. and
S. Pacific Ocean



△ STINGING GLOVES

Without the anemones, the crab is more or less defenseless, with little more than a picket of spines around the edge of its carapace.

△ SLY PREDATOR

The barracuda's silver scales reflect the water, helping it blend into the background, and the narrow head gives prey little chance of seeing it coming.



△ HERDING SCHOOL

Groups of barracudas will work together to herd schools of smaller fish into shallow waters, where they are easier to catch.

Green humphead parrotfish

Bolbometopon muricatum

The largest of all parrotfish, the green humphead is one of the most social—feeding, sleeping, and spawning in large groups. This makes it an easy target for spearfishers, and overfishing has led to a decline in numbers. Like all parrotfish, green humpheads eat live coral; they use their forehead bulge to ram reefs, breaking the coral down into small pieces, which they crush with their beaklike front teeth.

▷ REEF CRUNCHER

An adult parrotfish consumes around 6–7 tons (5–6 metric tons) of coral each year. Any hard, undigested material is passed out in the fish's feces, adding sediment back to the reef ecosystem.



↔ Up to 4 ft (1.2 m)

⚖ Up to 100 lb (50 kg)

⊗ Vulnerable

≡ Coral, algae



Indian Ocean, S. Pacific Ocean